

As George shows in his best-selling book, *Authentic Leadership*, these are more than stirring words. Authentic companies led by authentic leaders create solid business performance, building the intrinsic value of the enterprises they lead. These leaders build moral integrity into the fabric of the organization, and they create not just stock-price spikes but sustained growth in revenues and earnings per share. “The best path to long-term growth in shareholder value,” George writes, “comes from having a well-articulated mission that inspires employee commitment and the confidence and trust of clients.”

Listen, too, to legendary Boston College law professor Tamar Frankel in her impassioned book *Trust and Honesty: America’s Business Culture at a Crossroad*:

The real test for an honest and productive society is not what a society has achieved, but what it aims to achieve. It can put honest people on a pedestal even if they do not maximize their personal benefits and preferences . . . and discard and shun as models of failure dishonest people who achieve their highest ambitions by fraud and abuse of trust.

That echo of the impartial spectator helps provide the perspective we need. Bill George and Tamar Frankel exemplify the voices that will allow us to blend the best ideals of the eighteenth century with the compelling realities of the twenty-first century. These are the kinds of thinkers who will lead us to perhaps the most forgotten of all the qualities of that long-ago century—the central characteristic that those eighteenth-century versions of entrepreneurship, mutuality, and invention for the public weal have in common: *virtue*.

On Virtue

Today, *virtue* is a word that tends to make us uneasy. But it surely didn’t embarrass Benjamin Franklin. In 1728, when he was but 22